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Impact of social media on the psychological well-being of rural Youth- A systematic literature review and bibliometric analysis

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ABSTRACT

The rise of social media has profoundly influenced the mental health of young people, including rural youth who face unique socio-economic challenges. This systematic literature review and bibliometric analysis investigates the impact of social media on the psychological well-being of rural youth, examining both positive and negative aspects. Social media fosters social connectivity and educational access but also contributes to anxiety, depression and low self-esteem through social comparison and cyberbullying. A systematic search of peer-reviewed articles from 2019 to May 2024 was conducted using the Scopus database. Inclusion criteria focused on studies addressing the psychological effects of social media on rural youth. Data were analyzed using Bibliometrics, an R package for bibliometric analysis, to identify trends, collaborations and key themes. The findings highlight the dual nature of social media's impact. While it provides opportunities for interaction and access to resources, excessive or maladaptive use, particularly exposure to idealized content and cyberbullying, poses significant mental health risks. Rural youth are especially vulnerable due to isolation and limited access to mental health support. Understanding this nuanced role is vital for designing interventions that maximize social media's benefits while mitigating risks, promoting the psychological well-being of rural youth in the digital age.

1. Introduction

The rise of social media has profoundly transformed global communication patterns and social interactions, with far-reaching consequences for mental health and well-being. Social media platforms, including Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, and Snapchat, have not only become popular communication tools but have also integrated themselves into the very fabric of social life, especially among young people. In recent years, the notion of digital addiction has become popular[1]. Facebook and Snapchat employ different features for encouraging repeated, reinforced use of their platforms[2]. The rising popularity and prolonged use of Instagram have been linked to various negative effects on mental health, particularly among young people[3]. With the increasing accessibility of mobile technology and internet connectivity, rural youth, traditionally isolated from global information flows due to geographic, infrastructural and social barriers, are now experiencing unprecedented exposure to social media. According to Fiedler [4], rural youth is typically defined as individuals aged between 15 and 24 years living in rural areas, characterized by limited access to infrastructure, services and economic opportunities compared to their urban counterparts. This digital integration brings a myriad of both opportunities and challenges to the psychological well-being of rural youth, who often experience unique social, cultural and economic contexts that mediate their online interactions.

As rural youth increasingly engage with social media, its influence on their psychological well-being cannot be ignored. Research suggests that social media can act as a double-edged sword, offering both beneficial and harmful psychological effects depending on its use[5]. On one hand, it provides a platform for maintaining social connections, accessing educational resources and expressing emotions. On the other hand, issues such as cyberbullying, social comparison and information overload contribute to negative mental health outcomes, including anxiety, depression and reduced self-esteem[6]. Understanding how these dynamics play out among rural youth is critical, as their socio-cultural and

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economic environments often differ significantly from their urban counterparts, influencing how they engage with and are affected by social media.

The psychological impact of social media use can be examined through several theoretical frameworks, including social comparison theory, the social identity model of deindividuation effects (SIDE) and the uses and gratifications theory. Social comparison theory, proposed by Festinger [7], suggests that individuals evaluate themselves by comparing their lives, appearance and achievements with others. For rural youth, this process of comparison can be particularly detrimental, as the highly curated and often idealized images presented on social media platforms may exacerbate feelings of inadequacy, especially in the context of limited social and economic opportunities[8]. In a study of rural adolescents, researchers found that social comparison on platforms such as Instagram and Snapchat led to decreased life satisfaction and increased body dissatisfaction[9].

The SIDE model posits that anonymity and the reduced social cues characteristic of online interactions can lead to deindividuation, amplifying both prosocial and antisocial behaviors. For rural youth, who may already feel a sense of social isolation, the anonymity provided by social media can foster harmful behaviors like cyberbullying and trolling [10]. A study by Selkie et al. [11] found that rural adolescents were significantly more likely to experience cyberbullying than their urban peers, with serious consequences for their psychological well-being, including higher rates of anxiety, depression and suicidal ideation.

The uses and gratifications theory provides another lens for understanding the impact of social media on rural youth. This theory argues that individuals actively choose media sources based on their psychological and social needs[12]. For rural youth, social media often serves as a tool to overcome geographic isolation, enabling them to form social networks beyond their immediate community and access information and resources otherwise unavailable to them[13]. However, excessive or maladaptive use of social media, such as using it to escape from real-life problems or for validation, can lead to negative emotional outcomes [14].

Social media's impact on the psychological well-being of rural youth manifests in complex and multifaceted ways, with both positive and negative consequences. On the positive side, social media provides rural youth with a platform for social support and connection, which can buffer against the isolation and loneliness that often characterize rural living[15]. Social media allows young people to maintain relationships with peers and family members, fostering a sense of belonging and community even when physical interactions are limited. In rural areas, where mental health services and social support structures may be lacking, social media can serve as a valuable tool for accessing information about mental health and wellness, as well as creating support networks with peers facing similar challenges[6].

However, the negative consequences of social media use are equally significant. The increase in social media usage over the last ten years has been associated with a rise in suicide rates among youth[16]. Studies have consistently shown that excessive social media use is associated with increased symptoms of anxiety, depression and sleep disturbances among young people[17]. Increased screen time and social media usage might have transformed youth culture, potentially impacting the well-being of adolescents[18]. For rural youth, who may face additional challenges such as economic hardship, limited access to mental health resources and social stigma surrounding mental health issues, the effects of social media can be particularly detrimental[19]. A study by Nesi [20] found that youths who spent more time on social media were more likely to experience feelings of loneliness, social isolation and emotional distress, particularly when they engaged in passive consumption of content, such as scrolling through others' posts without actively participating.

Social comparison is another critical factor influencing the psychological well-being of rural youth. The carefully curated nature of social media content can create unrealistic expectations and foster a sense of inadequacy among young people, who may feel that their own lives do not measure up to the idealized images they see online (Fardouly et al. [9]). This can be particularly harmful for rural youth, who may already experience feelings of social or economic inferiority due to their geographic location[6]. Social media users frequently encounter images that portray idealized self-representations, which can threaten young people's self-esteem regarding their appearance. However, the extent of this negative impact may vary based on the types of engagement with social media[21].

Despite the growing body of research on social media's impact on youth, significant gaps remain, particularly in understanding how these platforms affect rural populations. While urban youth may have greater access to mental health services and social support networks, rural youth often face unique challenges that exacerbate the negative effects of social media[22]. These barriers include geographic isolation and limited availability of mental health infrastructure, but also extend to low levels of digital literacy which is the ability to critically assess, navigate and engage with digital content effectively. Research indicates that rural youth are often less digitally literate compared to their urban counterparts, making them more vulnerable to online misinformation, cyberbullying and passive content consumption, which are associated with negative mental health outcomesVan Deursen and Van Dijk [23]. This digital skills gap can limit their ability to benefit from the positive aspects of social media, such as access to online support groups or educational content, while increasing their exposure to its psychological harms. Although several studies have explored the relationship between social media use and youth mental health, most systematic reviews have primarily focused on urban populations or generalized youth demographics, without isolating the experiences of rural youth. To the best of our knowledge, there is a lack of comprehensive reviews that specifically synthesize the existing literature on how social media influences the psychological well-being of rural youth. Given the growing digital integration of rural areas and the distinct socio-cultural contexts of rural youth, this review aims to fill that critical gap by offering a focused, evidence-based understanding of the psychological implications of social media use in rural settings.

The primary objective of this systematic review is to examine and synthesize the existing literature on the psychological impact of social media on rural youth, with a specific emphasis on mental health outcomes such as anxiety, depression, self-esteem and emotional well-being. The review also aims to explore the influence of mediating factors such as social support networks, coping mechanisms and personality traits that shape the relationship between social media use and mental health.

In order to contextualize the available research and identify gaps in the literature, this review incorporates a bibliometric analysis. This includes an examination of publication trends, journal outlets, country-level contributions and disciplinary affiliations. These bibliometric insights help to assess the scope, geographical distribution and interdisciplinary nature of the research landscape on this topic. Together, the bibliometric and content analyses contribute to a comprehensive understanding of how digital platforms affect the psychological well-being of rural youth, while also guiding future research directions and policy interventions.

2. Methodology

A systematic literature review or SLR, is a methodical and thorough process for locating, assessing and integrating previous research on a particular subject or research question. It is a way to identify, analyze and interpret all available studies related to a single research question or phenomena of interest[24]. The Systematic Literature Review (SLR) was chosen for this review due of its systematic, transparent and repeatable methods for choosing and building a database for the analysis. The study was guided by the PRISMA (Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic reviews and Meta-Analyses) Statement[25].

2.1. Document search

The scholarly electronic database Scopus was used to find relevant studies on the effects of social media on youth as part of the systematic literature review. Scopus was chosen as it is a trustworthy source for top-notch scholarly research because of its extensive academic coverage, strict indexing guidelines and thorough inclusion of peer-reviewed literature from a variety of disciplines.

While other databases such as Web of Science and PubMed also offer valuable resources, Scopus was prioritized for its integrated coverage of both health-related and behavioral science literature within a single platform, which aligns with the interdisciplinary nature of this review. However, the reliance on a single database is acknowledged as a limitation, and future reviews may benefit from including additional databases such as Web of Science and PubMed to enhance the breadth and robustness of the literature search.

Research articles were identified through carefully selected keyword combinations. The final search string was refined with necessary adjustments and expert consultation to ensure precision and relevance. To capture the most recent and comprehensive insights, the search was restricted to publications from 2019 to May 2024, providing a contemporary understanding of the impact of social media on youth, while ensuring that the findings reflect current trends and developments in the field.

The initial search and keyword filtering were conducted using automated functions in the database (i.e., title, abstract and keyword fields). However, the screening and selection of studies were performed manually by two independent reviewers. Each reviewer screened all titles and abstracts independently, following pre-established inclusion and exclusion criteria. Discrepancies or disagreements between reviewers were resolved through discussion, and a third reviewer was consulted when necessary to reach a consensus. This process ensured objectivity, reduced selection bias and increased the reliability of study inclusion.

Table 1 provides an overview of the search strategy, including keyword combinations used and Boolean operators applied.

2.2. Article screening and development of literature review

Using predefined inclusion and exclusion criteria, the records were screened in multiple stages (Table 2):

1. Deduplication: Duplicate records were automatically removed using Scopus tools and manually verified.
2. Title and Abstract Screening: Two independent reviewers screened the titles and abstracts based on the presence of predefined keywords (Table 1). Studies that did not align with the research focus were excluded. Discrepancies between reviewers were resolved through consensus and a third reviewer.
3. Full-Text Review: Articles that passed the initial screening were subjected to full-text evaluation. Studies were included if they explicitly addressed the psychological impact of social media on youth, particularly in rural settings.

Table 1
Combination of Keywords used and Total number of articles.

Database	Search terms/Keywords	Numbers of Articles
Scopus	"Social media" OR "Digital media platform" OR "Social network" OR "Networking site" OR "Social Channels" AND "youth" OR "Rural young adults" OR "Village youth" OR "Rural Young population" OR "Rural youth" AND "psychological impact" OR "Emotional well-being" OR "Cognitive effects"	2097

Table 2
Inclusion and Exclusion Criteria.

Parameter	Inclusion criteria	Exclusion criteria
Initial identification		
Publishing year	2019–2024	If published before 2019
Document type	Article	Review, Conference paper, Book Chapter, Book
Subject Area	Social Science, Psychology, Computer Science, Multidisciplinary, Health Profession, Agricultural and Biological Science	Medicine, Arts and Humanities, Nursing, Engineering, Environmental Science, Business, Management and Accounting
Language	English	French and Spanish
Source type	Journal	Conference Proceedings, Book, Book Series
Publishing stage	Final	Article in press
Access type	Open Access	Restricted Access

4. Eligibility and Relevance Check: The remaining articles were reviewed for non-redundancy and relevance to the research objectives.
5. Synthesis: The final selected studies were thematically synthesized to explore how social media influences the psychological well-being of rural youth.

A PRISMA flow diagram (Fig. 1) illustrates the process of study identification, screening and inclusion.

2.3. Method of data analysis

Recent advancements in bibliometrics software have made it possible to analyze specific scientific fields, topics or subjects of interest. An open-source tool for thorough scientific mapping, the Bibliometrics package was created in the R programming language. With a variety of graphical and statistical features, it gives users freedom and is updated frequently to guarantee its efficacy[26]. The program creates a collaborative network when several writers work together on an article, which aids in clarifying the dynamics involved in producing these studies [27].

The program creates a network of terms by identifying keywords that commonly occur together. High density is indicated by a network with a large number of co-occurring keywords. After that, the program assesses the relationships between this term network and others, classifying the words into subject areas and arranging themes according to their density and centrality[28].

3. Results

The Bibliometrics RStudio-4.3.2 win software was used for the descriptive analysis for the bibliometric investigation. The most widely used R package, biblio-metrics, is being utilized in an increasing number of papers[29]. The bibliometric data from the Scopus database can be directly exported to the R. System R is recognized as the de-facto standard platform for statistical algorithm creation and is one of the dynamic software tools used for data analysis and visualization (view of mapping research on using Biblioshiny)[30]. In addition, the TCCM (Theory, Context, Characteristics, Methodology) framework was carried out to thematically structure and analyze the selected literature.

3.1. Bibliometric analysis

Fig. 2 illustrates the number of scientific articles produced each year from 2019 to 2024. It reveals a trend of fluctuating productivity, where the production of articles remained relatively low from 2019 to 2021, with a slight increase in 2021. A noticeable increase is observed in 2022, peaking in 2023 with around 20 articles produced. In 2024, a slight

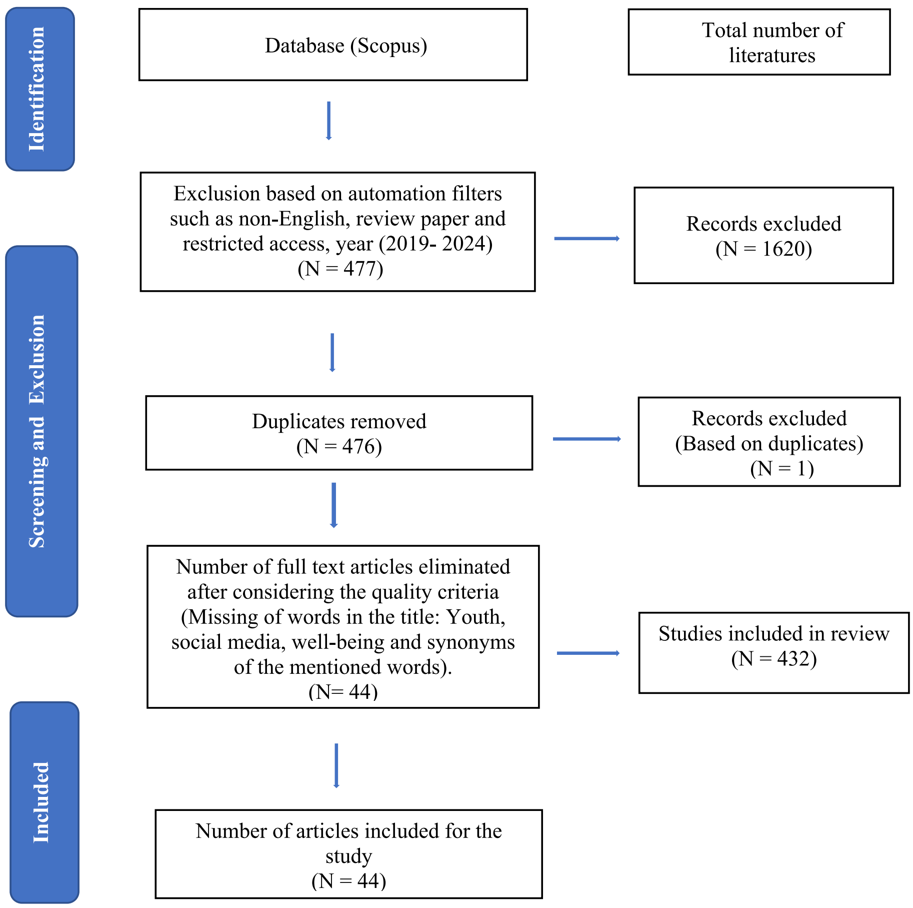

Fig. 1. PRISMA Flowchart.

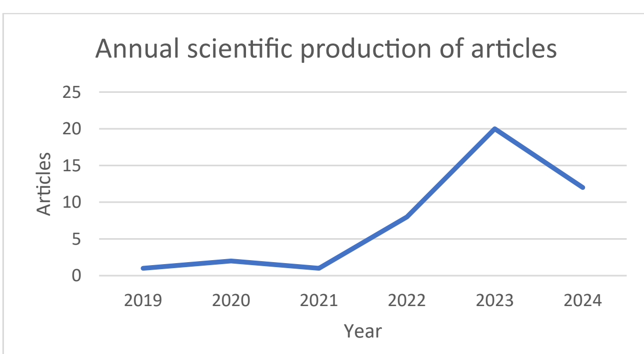

Fig. 2. Analysis of annual scientific production on articles for the period 2019–2024.

decline in the number of publications is observed. However, given that the data collection only covers part of the year, this figure may not represent the final annual output. Overall, the data highlights the dynamic nature of scientific productivity, with both peaks and declines influenced by various contextual elements.

Fig. 3 illustrates the distribution of articles across academic journals included in this review. Among the open-access sources analyzed, Current Psychology accounted for the highest number of publications (n = 5), followed by BMC Psychology and Heliyon, each contributing three articles. While this may suggest a degree of relevance of Current Psychology to the topic under investigation, it is important to interpret these findings with caution. The identification of Current Psychology as the leading source in this dataset does not necessarily imply that it is the most influential or comprehensive journal in the field overall. This pattern is likely influenced by the scope of this review, which was limited exclusively to open-access literature.

As such, it is possible that other high-impact journals that do not publish content in open access may have produced a larger body of work on the subject, but were not included in the current analysis due to accessibility constraints. Therefore, the frequency of publications from individual journals should be viewed as reflective of trends within open-access publishing, rather than as a definitive measure of domain authority.

Nevertheless, the presence of articles across a wide range of journals including those in psychology, health sciences, sustainability and social sciences highlights the interdisciplinary nature of research on social media and youth mental health. This diversity emphasizes the importance of integrating insights from multiple academic domains to address such complex and multifaceted social issues.

Fig. 4 illustrates the distribution of scientific production by country. Spain is shown as the leading country with the highest frequency of scientific production, followed by Thailand, China and the USA. It effectively demonstrates the concentration of scientific output in a few nations, suggesting that a small set of regions dominate in producing scientific research, while many others lag behind. This pattern could reflect disparities in research infrastructure, investment and scientific capacity between countries. The inclusion of lesser-contributing countries highlights the global nature of scientific production but also underscores the gap between leading and lower-tier nations in terms of research outputs.

The Table 3 presents data on various academic papers, including their total citations (TC) and citations per year. The paper by Apaolaza V, published in *Cyberpsychology, Behavior, and Social Networking* in 2019,

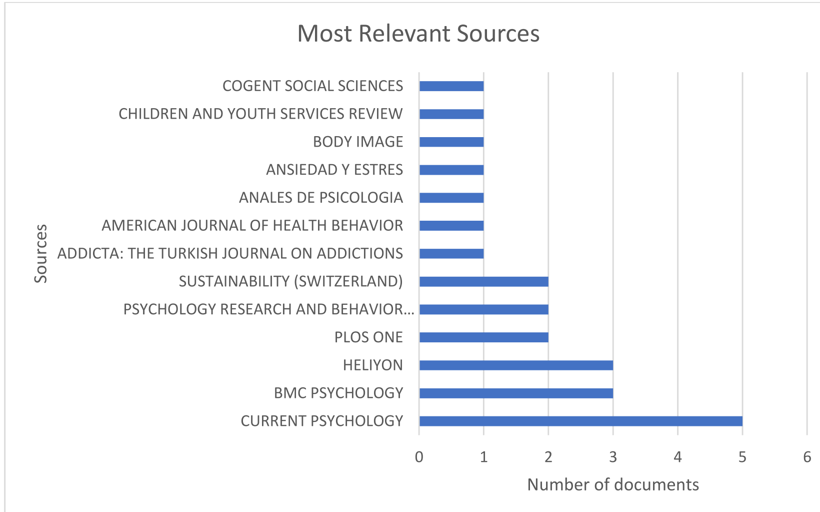

Fig. 3. Analysis of most relevant sources for the period 2019–2024.

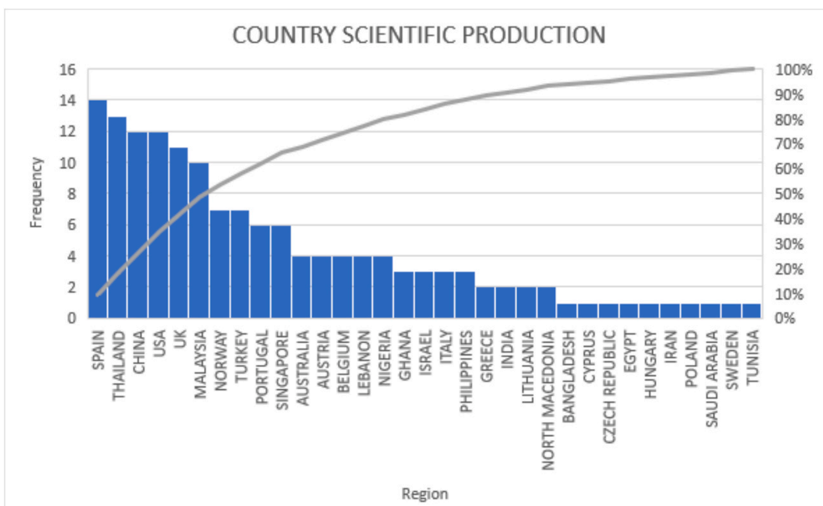

Fig. 4. Analysis of Country wise scientific production for the period 2019–2024.

leads with 84 total citations, averaging 14 citations per year, highlighting its significant impact and recognition within the academic community. McCrory A's 2020 paper in *Child and Youth Services Review* follows with 30 citations and 6 citations per year, indicating consistent academic engagement. Other notable contributions include Miranda S's 2023 paper in *Technological Forecasting and Social Change* (21 citations, 10.5 per year) and Caner N's 2022 paper in *Current Psychology* (16 citations, 5.33 per year).

Several papers, such as those by Wong et al. [43], Shahzalal M (2022), and Zhang C (2023), show a lower total citation count but maintain respectable citation rates per year, indicating they are relatively recent but gaining attention. Conversely, some papers, like those by Mao J (2023) and Voss C (2023), have lower citation totals (2 citations each) and 1 citation per year, likely due to their recent publication.

The Fig. 5 presents a thematic map; a strategic diagram used in bibliometric and content analysis. This thematic map provides insight into the structure of the research field, indicating that topics related to "social media" and gender ("female" and "human") are central to the field, while areas like "mental health" and "young adult" focus on more specific, specialized studies. The declining or emerging relevance of "social-networking" suggests a shifting focus in how online interactions are studied in this context. This map provides a guide for future research by highlighting both well-established and developing areas of interest.

The Table 5 provides an intricate network analysis that highlights two dominant research clusters: social media and mental health, examining their interconnectedness through keyword occurrences and centrality metrics, such as betweenness centrality, closeness centrality, and PageRank. The social media cluster emerges as the most prominent theme, with the term "social media" itself appearing 12 times and exhibiting high centrality, signifying its role as a focal point in the broader research field. Other keywords within this cluster, including "female", "male", and "human", suggest that gender dynamics and human interaction are crucial aspects of social media studies. Additionally, the presence of terms such as "adolescent", "adult", "student" and "self-concept" indicates that much of the research in this area is focused on understanding the psychological and behavioral impacts of social media across different age groups and life stages. Furthermore, the inclusion of terms like "anxiety", "mindfulness" and "psychology" reveals the growing interest in the intersection between social media use and mental health outcomes, with psychological well-being being a central concern.

The second cluster, mental health, is closely linked to the study of social networks and online interactions, with "mental health" itself appearing four times. The table shows that researchers are particularly

Table 3
Most global cited documents.

Papers	TOTAL CITATIONS (TC)	TC PER YEAR
Apaolaza V, [31], Cyberpsychology, Behaviour Social Networking	84	14
Mccrory A, [32], Child and Youth Service Review	30	6
Miranda S, [33], Technological and Forecasting Social Change	21	10.5
Caner N, [34], Current Psychology	16	5.33333333
Kim Yk, [35], Journal of Social and Personal Relationships	12	4
Thumronglaohapun S, [36], Plos One	11	3.66666667
Lajnef K, [37], Current Psychology	9	4.5
Ali Si, [38], Sustainability	8	2.66666667
Phillips Wj, [39], Computers in Human Behavior Reports	8	2
Sánchez-Fernández M, [40], Education and Information Technologies	7	3.5
Stieger S, [41], Body Image	7	2.33333333
Cleofas Jv, [42] Health Promotion Perspectives	7	2.33333333
Wong J, [43], Current Psychology	6	6
Shahzalal M, [44], Sustainability	6	2
Zhang C, [45], BMC Psychology	5	2.5
Tomczyk Ł, [46], International Journal of Telematics and Informatics	5	2.5
Yang C–C, [47], Heliyon	4	2
Lamash L, [48], The Journal of Adolescence	2	2
Sun L, [49], BMC Psychology	2	1
El Frenn Y, [50], Current Psychology	2	1
Mao J, [22], Psychology Research and Behavior Management	2	1
Voss C, [51] International Journal of Digital Healthcare	2	1

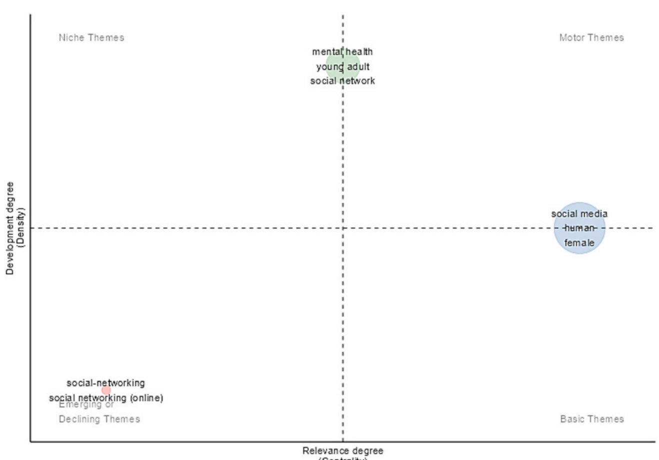

Fig. 5. Thematic map.

interested in how social networking, addiction and well-being are influenced by mental health, as evidenced by terms like "young adult", "social network" and "addiction". The connection between mental health and online behaviors is further supported by the appearance of terms such as "fear of missing out(FOMO)", "motivation" and "questionnaire", reflecting how these psychological constructs are being used to explore the effects of online engagement on mental health. Methodologically, the table highlights the use of approaches like "ecological momentary assessment" and "cross-sectional studies" to gather real-time data or analyze broader population-level trends in social media usage and its relationship with mental health.

3.2. TCCM framework

3.2.1. TCCM framework analysis

The TCCM (Theory–Context–Characteristics–Methodology) framework offers a structured lens to synthesize the breadth of insights gathered through the systematic literature review on the psychological impacts of social media on youth, particularly rural youth. This section elaborates on each element of the framework in detail, connecting them to the reviewed body of 44 scholarly articles.

3.2.2. Theory (T)

A foundational understanding of social media's psychological impacts is anchored in theoretical frameworks, although theory application remains inconsistent across the literature. The most widely referenced theory is Social Comparison Theory[7], utilized in studies like McCrory et al. [32] and Díaz-Moreno et al. [52] to explain how adolescents evaluate themselves against curated online personas. This process is particularly detrimental among rural youth, who may have limited social reference points offline and rely heavily on social media for identity cues.

Uses and Gratifications Theory informs several studies that explore the motivations behind youth engagement with social media platforms. Kasmani et al. [53] and López-Sáez et al. [54] highlight that youth often turn to social platforms for self-expression, entertainment and social connection, which can either enhance or undermine mental well-being depending on the quality and context of usage.

Theory of Planned Behavior was employed by Shahzalal and Adnan [44] to understand how attitudes, perceived behavioral control and normative beliefs influence responsible social media usage. Meanwhile, cognitive-behavioral models underpin research on cyberbullying and sadfishing behaviors, as seen in the works of Ali and Shahbuddin [38] and Shabahang et al. [55].

Digital mindfulness frameworks are emerging as practical approaches to mitigate harm. Sun [49] and Phillips and Wisniewski [39] found that mindfulness and self-compassion serve as buffers against the negative emotional consequences of compulsive digital behavior.

Despite these valuable applications, a notable gap persists: many studies are descriptive or exploratory and lack theoretical integration. This limits the explanatory power of findings and underscores the need for stronger theory-driven research in future investigations.

3.2.3. Context (C)

The contextual scope of existing studies is broad yet uneven. A large portion of the research is concentrated in urban and university settings, with countries like China, Turkey, India, Spain and the United States dominating the literature (e.g., [39],Gökçearslan et al. [56,22]. The scarcity of studies targeting rural youth populations is a critical limitation, although a few exceptions exist (e.g., [57]; S & S, [58]; [59].

Geographic diversity in the reviewed literature is notable but still insufficient. While the presence of research from Africa[57,59], Southeast Asia and Latin America offers some cross-cultural insights, most studies do not explicitly address local cultural norms, values, or infrastructure disparities that may shape youth experiences.

The age groups studied typically range from adolescents (12–19) to young adults (18–25), with very few longitudinal studies tracking developmental outcomes over time[60]. Furthermore, the gender and sexual identity inclusiveness is limited, although some studies like López-Sáez et al. [54] attempt to address minority stress among LGB youth.

The socio-historical context is also relevant: several studies were conducted during or shortly after the COVID-19 pandemic (e.g., [61,33], reflecting a surge in digital dependency and corresponding psychological challenges. However, few studies incorporate temporal comparison or control for pre-pandemic conditions.

Table 5
Occurrences and centrality measures of keywords in clusters.

Words	Occurrences	Cluster Label	Btw Centrality	Clos Centrality	Page rank Centrality
social-networking	2	social-networking	181.958186	0.0033557	0.0075045
social networking (online)	2	social-networking	181.958186	0.0033557	0.0075045
social media	12	social media	2436.25065	0.00478469	0.03321685
female	8	social media	780.740948	0.00423729	0.02396059
male	7	social media	457.625103	0.004329	0.02207234
human	10	social media	659.146231	0.00429185	0.02751061
adolescent	5	social media	177.045168	0.00353357	0.01290784
adult	7	social media	538.19628	0.00420168	0.02121159
article	7	social media	535.596596	0.00436681	0.02179434
humans	7	social media	264.843519	0.00353357	0.01884576
psychology	6	social media	458.568959	0.00406504	0.01918058
human experiment	5	social media	373.091501	0.00421941	0.0181074
social interaction	2	social media	72.6995099	0.00318471	0.00692983
anxiety	2	social media	22.9962402	0.00322581	0.00471651
mindfulness	2	social media	22.9962402	0.00322581	0.00471651
self concept	2	social media	11.5110083	0.00287356	0.00472212
student	4	social media	261.622186	0.00342466	0.00985771
child	2	social media	39.8557504	0.00320513	0.00779524
controlled study	3	social media	108.190542	0.00333333	0.00960523
major clinical study	3	social media	70.3421567	0.00318471	0.00920157
cross-sectional studies	2	social media	31.3221281	0.00316456	0.00710973
cross-sectional study	2	social media	31.3221281	0.00316456	0.00710973
students	2	social media	26.9442729	0.00309598	0.00590588
ecological momentary assessment	2	mental health	158.024207	0.00377358	0.00993115
young adult	3	mental health	93.5337098	0.00369004	0.01070101
internet	2	mental health	124.335042	0.00374532	0.009138
mental health	4	mental health	574.870873	0.00401606	0.01360149
social network	3	mental health	311.726754	0.00377358	0.01239319
addiction	3	mental health	1135.94881	0.00395257	0.0135328
motivation	2	mental health	199.47051	0.00384615	0.01043919
fear of missing out	2	mental health	50.4252217	0.00364964	0.00827444
questionnaire	2	mental health	170.216916	0.003861	0.01061141
social networking	2	mental health	68.4733353	0.003663	0.00881946
wellbeing	2	mental health	170.216916	0.003861	0.01061141

3.2.4. Characteristics (C)

The characteristics of research variables in the reviewed studies span psychological, behavioral, social and technological domains. Mental health outcomes such as anxiety, depression, self-esteem and emotional well-being are central constructs in the majority of works[62,61,45]. Alongside these are emergent variables like Fear of Missing Out (FoMO), problematic social media use and social appearance anxiety[34]; Sánchez-Fernández & Borda-Mas, 2022).

Behavioral characteristics include screen time, procrastination, academic disengagement and compulsive usage patterns[33,63]. Several studies also assess coping strategies such as distraction, rumination and escapism, particularly in the context of cyberbullying[64,36].

Social characteristics including peer influence, social support and online communication skills are explored using validated psychometric tools[35,65]. Some studies focus on the impact of influencers and parasocial relationships, demonstrating how digital personalities shape identity and emotional responses[37].

On the technological side, platforms such as Instagram, TikTok, Facebook and Snapchat dominate the discourse. Yet, other fast-growing digital spaces like Discord and BeReal remain underexplored[32].

3.2.5. Methodology (M)

The reviewed studies employ diverse methodological approaches, yet the dominance of quantitative cross-sectional designs remains evident (e.g., [42,52,22]. While these methods provide breadth, they often fall short in establishing causal relationships and capturing temporal dynamics.

A smaller body of work employs experimental or longitudinal panel designs, providing more robust evidence for causal inference[66,60]. Ecological momentary assessments and real-time behavior tracking are also gaining traction[41,67].

Qualitative and mixed-methods research is increasingly used to explore nuanced experiences, especially in culturally rich or emotionally complex contexts[53,68,69]. Tools like cognitive mapping[37]and content analysis[70]complement traditional survey instruments.

Analytical tools span from descriptive statistics and correlation matrices to structural equation modeling (SEM), SmartPLS, and NVivo. However, methodological inconsistency across studies such as varying measurement scales and definitions of "problematic use" remains a challenge, as noted by Wong et al. [43].

Future research would benefit from adopting longitudinal, culturally inclusive and intervention-based methodologies, offering not only insights into risk but also pathways toward resilience.

This TCCM analysis underscores both the richness and fragmentation of the literature. While there is increasing recognition of the importance of social media in shaping youth mental health, particularly among rural populations, the field would greatly benefit from more theory-driven, context-sensitive and methodologically rigorous research moving forward.

4. Discussion

This section synthesizes the key insights drawn from the 44 reviewed studies, providing a comprehensive analysis of the psychological impacts of social media use among youth, with an emphasis on rural populations. The discussion is structured around four core themes derived from the systematic review framework: Methodology, Measured Variables, Main Findings and Limitations. This structure allows for a critical exploration of how research in this domain has evolved, what variables are most frequently assessed, the central trends that emerge from empirical findings, and where the gaps and limitations in existing literature lie.

4.1. Methodology followed in the reviewed articles

The reviewed studies employed a diverse range of methodological approaches, reflecting the complexity of investigating the psychological impact of social media on youth. A substantial number of studies adopted cross-sectional survey designs[38,34,42,52],Gökçearslan et al. [56], which allowed researchers to capture correlations between social media use and mental health outcomes. Others incorporated experimental[66]and longitudinal panel designs[60], offering stronger inferential validity and temporal insights. Further contributions came from Gao & Fu [71] and Voss et al. [51], who utilized longitudinal and real-time behavioral tracking methods, respectively.

Qualitative methods were utilized to uncover in-depth perspectives, particularly in studies exploring lived experiences and personal reflections[53,69,59]. Mixed-method approaches, such as those by Nawi et al. [68] and Da Silva Gomes et al. [64], enriched the understanding by integrating statistical trends with thematic insights. Several systematic reviews and *meta*-analyses[32,40],Wong et al. [43]contributed broad overviews of existing literature, highlighting research gaps and methodological shortcomings.

Ecological momentary assessments[41,67]and experience sampling methods provided real-time data on emotional states, while content analysis[70]and cognitive mapping[37]enabled the examination of media portrayals and mental schemas. The diversity in methodological design underscores the interdisciplinary interest in this field, spanning psychology, communication, education and health sciences.

4.2. Measured variables in the studies

The variables measured across studies reflected key psychological, behavioral and social constructs relevant to youth well-being. Mental health indicators, such as anxiety, depression, self-esteem and emotional well-being were predominant[62,61,39,45]. Constructs like Fear of Missing Out (FoMO), social appearance anxiety and problematic social media use were also frequently explored[34],Gökçearslan et al. [56,40].

Behavioral metrics such as screen time, platform preference, academic engagement, procrastination and communication skills were assessed using standardized scales[48,72,49,63]. Emotion regulation strategies, including distraction and rumination, were measured in studies addressing cyberbullying and interpersonal stress[64,36].

Interpersonal and social constructs like online peer norms, social support and prosocial behavior were evaluated using established psychometric tools[35,54,65,44]. Some studies introduced context-specific variables such as influencer exposure[37], sadfishing[55], academic peer pressure[73]and minority stress[54], reflecting an evolving landscape of digital youth experiences.

4.3. Main findings from the reviewed article

The findings across studies depict a nuanced and multi-layered relationship between social media use and youth mental health. Problematic use, characterized by addictive behaviors and compulsive engagement, was consistently associated with heightened anxiety, depression and emotional distress[52,74,22,33]; S & S, 2023) [58]. Conversely, reflective and purposeful engagement particularly when paired with self-compassion or mindfulness was linked to positive outcomes such as emotional resilience and well-being[31,49],Wong et al. [43].

Visual social media platforms, especially Instagram and TikTok, emerged as potent triggers of body image dissatisfaction, particularly among adolescent girls[34,32,41]. Influencer content played a central role in shaping youth aspirations and behaviors, with trust and authenticity identified as key mechanisms of impact[37].

Cyberbullying and emotional vulnerability online were shown to elicit sadness, worry and reduced perceived social support[38,55,36]. Kasmani et al. [53] found that youth who disclosed their emotions online reported feelings of connection and flourishing, suggesting a therapeutic potential when such platforms are used constructively. Several studies also found that digital coping strategies like accessing social support networks could mediate the harmful psychological effects of excessive social media use [47,45].

Academic implications were equally pronounced. Students with higher screen time or FoMO were more prone to procrastination and disengagement[65,73,63]. However, when prosocial norms and emotional regulation were present, students exhibited more responsible social media behavior[44].

The reviewed literature also points to the role of digital platforms in shaping youth perceptions of trust[71], mental well-being during national crises[61]and the use of mobile apps for psychological self-help [69]. Disruptive online behaviors during crisis times, including performative spirituality and self-promotion, were discussed by Nawi et al. [68], while S & S [58] investigated impacts in rural Indian contexts.

4.4. Limitations

Despite the rich insights, the reviewed literature is not without limitations. Most studies adopted cross-sectional designs, restricting causal interpretations[60,39,46]. Reliance on self-reported data across several studies introduced recall bias and social desirability effects[62], Gökçearslan et al. [56].

Cultural and geographical representativeness also posed a concern. Many studies were conducted in urban or university settings, leaving rural youth underrepresented[57,59]. Gender and sexual orientation biases were noted in studies where female or LGB participants exhibited distinct patterns of emotional response and well-being[42,54].

A number of studies focused heavily on specific platforms (e.g., Facebook, Instagram), potentially overlooking emerging digital spaces like Discord or BeReal that may be more relevant to today's youth[32]. Furthermore, conceptual ambiguities such as varied definitions of problematic use and inconsistent measurement tools hampered cross-study comparabilityWong et al. [40,43].

Finally, although some intervention studies reported promising results, most lacked longitudinal follow-up, limiting understanding of long-term effectiveness[69,49]. Future research must adopt mixed-method, longitudinal and culturally inclusive designs to offer a more comprehensive picture of the psychological impact of social media on rural youth.

5. Conclusion

In summary, social media serves as a double-edged sword for rural youth, offering both remarkable opportunities and considerable challenges that significantly affect their psychological well-being. On one hand, it facilitates vital connections, enhances social engagement and provides access to educational resources that may otherwise be unavailable due to geographical constraints. On the other hand, the pervasive issues of social comparison, cyberbullying and social media overload present substantial risks that can undermine mental health.

To address these complexities, it is crucial to adopt a comprehensive approach that encompasses targeted interventions and resources tailored to the unique needs of rural youth. Such initiatives should focus on fostering digital literacy, emotional resilience and supportive online communities to help young people navigate the digital landscape responsibly. By promoting awareness of the potential risks and encouraging healthy social media practices, stakeholders can empower rural youth to harness the benefits of social media while mitigating its adverse effects.

Future research should continue to explore the evolving dynamics of social media use and its implications for mental health, particularly in rural contexts. Through collaborative efforts among educators, mental health professionals and community leaders, we can cultivate a supportive environment that enhances the psychological well-being of rural youth in the digital age.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Appendix A. Supplementary data

Supplementary data to this article can be found online at https://doi.org/10.1016/j.entcom.2025.101012.

Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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